

Leighton Van Ness

AI Operations, Implementation & Customer-Facing Systems Lead

New York, NY | 203.564.0116 | leighton@vanness.net | LinkedIn | GitHub | Portfolio

SUMMARY

AI operations, implementation, and customer-facing systems leader who builds internal tools, operational platforms, GTM workflows, and AI-enabled processes. Translate business needs into practical systems spanning product operations, workflow automation, client delivery, and revenue operations. Bring hands-on technical fluency across APIs, modern web platforms, CRM systems, analytics, and deployment workflows.

EXPERIENCE

Elevate Experiences | VP, Innovation

New York, NY | 2024 - Present

- Built and manage the Elevate Dashboard, a shared operations platform for event planning, ticketing, user administration, vendor and talent coordination, and production management.
- Developed the platform with React, serverless Node.js APIs, Redis/Upstash, Google Sheets integrations, and role-based access controls on Vercel.
- Established CI/CD, preview deployments, automated tests, production safeguards, PDF/Word exports, and recurring release verification.
- Lead AI and workflow implementation, evaluating tools, piloting practical use cases, and helping teams apply AI systems to operating workflows.
- Built an AI prospecting agent with API integrations that identifies and qualifies prospects, manages sending infrastructure, launches targeted outbound campaigns, and has generated new leads.
- Oversee technical production for approximately 25 virtual events annually and 5-10 private concerts and large-format live experiences.
- Led the Elevate Experiences website launch and now manage SEO, analytics, content, inquiry flows, and HubSpot- and Salesforce-connected GTM workflows.
- Built an automated logistics tracker supporting approximately 60 events, 600 shipped bins, and 12,000-24,000 items with status syncing, alerts, routing, and recovery workflows.

Zinc Agency | VP, Innovation & Technology

New York, NY | 2020 - 2024

- Led the company's pivot to virtual programming during COVID, building the technical platform that preserved service delivery and expanded virtual event offerings.
- Implemented Hive as the division's core project management system, creating custom workflows, forms, automations, and Salesforce-connected operating structure still used across Zinc Agency and Elevate Experiences.
- Engineered a custom streaming and registration platform using WordPress, JavaScript, web APIs, embedded meeting tools, and reusable branded event workflows.
- Supported more than 2,000 celebrity-led livestreams, managing technical specifications, talent coordination, and production stakeholders.
- Repurposed the platform into InviteMeNow, a customizable registration system for in-person, virtual, and hybrid client experiences.

Zinc Agency | Director of Products

New York, NY | 2018 - 2020

- Led budget creation, experience pricing, product packaging, and sales strategy for premium entertainment and experiential offerings.
- Managed contracts, legal agreements, talent and venue requirements, and critical coordination among artists, representatives, and event stakeholders.

Creative Artists Agency | Account Executive

New York, NY | 2014 - 2018

- Developed experiential concepts using CAA-represented talent for corporate buyers and premium client programs.
- Managed sold-event logistics, agency coordination, venue planning, transportation, concierge details, and client communication.

TECHNICAL & AI SKILLS

AI & Automation: AI tools, prospecting agents, prompt/workflow design, research automation, API integrations, Apps Script, Zapier

Platforms & GTM Systems: Salesforce, HubSpot, ZoomInfo, Outreach, Google Analytics, SEO, Google Sheets

Product Engineering: JavaScript, TypeScript, React, Node.js, Express, REST APIs, GraphQL, Redis, MongoDB, MySQL

Delivery & Quality: Vercel, GitHub, CI/CD, Playwright, Jest, auth and permissions, deployment verification, PDF/Word exports

EDUCATION & CERTIFICATIONS

CU Boulder - M.S. Computer Science, Estimated Completion 2026

New York University - Management, 2011 - 2013

University of St. Andrews - Economics, 2009 - 2011

Columbia Engineering Coding Boot Camp Professional Certificate, 2024

IBM Full Stack Software Developer Professional Certificate, 2023